

C4 Diagram Legend Card

Day 3 · Activity 1 handout. Every C4 diagram needs a legend so non-architects can read it. A diagram without a legend is a Rorschach test — force the legend.

The legend (copy onto every diagram)

Legend

- □ Box with no fill = system / module owned by us
- ■ Box with fill = external system (out of our control)
- 👤 Stick figure / labeled box = person (role)
- → Solid arrow = synchronous call
- → Dashed arrow = async / event
- (label on arrow) = intent in plain English

The two levels we draw (and why only two)

LEVEL	WHAT IT SHOWS	AUDIENCE	WE DRAW IT?
Context	The system + its users + neighbors	Everyone, including stakeholders	✅ Today
Container	Deployable units inside the system	TPMs, architects, devs	✅ Today
Component	Code-level building blocks within a container	Engineers	❌ Engineering job
Code	Class-level detail	Engineers	❌ Engineering job

Context + Container is TPM scope.

Context diagram (Level 1) — the rules

Answers: *who interacts with this system, and what other systems does it talk to?*

Include: **people** (roles), the **one system in scope**, and **external systems**. Arrows carry brief intent labels ("submits reconcile" / "issues SSO token" / "writes audit events").

Deliberately NOT in the Context diagram: database choices, internal services, protocols (REST vs gRPC), hostnames, environments, deployment units.

Keep it under **12 boxes**. If it has 20, you're sneaking Container concerns in.

Container diagram (Level 2) — the rules

Answers: *inside the system, what are the deployable units, and how do they talk?*

A **container** is anything you'd update independently — a web app, a mobile app, a service, a database, a queue, a CDN, an event bus. Arrows show protocol and direction with brief intent labels.

A **modular monolith** looks like *one* big container with internal modules listed as sub-boxes. A **microservice split** looks like *multiple* containers. The container diagram is where the Day-1 stance becomes visible — don't promote modules to standalone containers without justification.